

Beautiful, Sublime, or Neither? Kant's Puzzle of Subjective Universality

An original lesson plan inspired by **Immanuel Kant (trans. J. H. Bernard)**'s *Critique of Judgement* (Project Gutenberg). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Project Gutenberg or Immanuel Kant (trans. J. H. Bernard). Explore the original course: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/48433>

GRADE LEVEL

Undergraduate / Graduate Seminar

DURATION

70 minutes

TOPICS

Aesthetics

“Kant claims that a judgment like 'this is beautiful' is grounded purely in a private feeling of pleasure, yet nonetheless demands universal agreement from every other rational being — can these two claims possibly be reconciled, and does Kant's account of the 'free play' of our faculties actually succeed in reconciling them?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Reconstruct Kant's four 'moments' of the judgment of taste: disinterestedness, subjective universality, purposiveness without a purpose, and necessity.
- Explain the 'free play' of imagination and understanding as Kant's proposed ground for aesthetic pleasure, and why he thinks this ground can support a claim to universal validity without a determinate concept.
- Distinguish the beautiful from the mathematical and dynamical sublime, and evaluate whether Kant's overall framework successfully bridges subjective feeling and universal claim.

Materials Needed

- Excerpt packet with short passages corresponding to each of the four moments, the free-play passage, and the sublime passages (mathematical and dynamical)
- Seminar discussion guide with close-reading prompts for each excerpt
- Whiteboard for building the four-moments chart
- A short case for application: a description of a vast landscape or violent storm, to test the sublime

Lesson Procedure

Framing: The Paradox of Taste

10 min

Open by stating the paradox baldly: Kant thinks 'X is beautiful' is not a claim about X at all, only about the feeling X produces in you — yet he also thinks that in making the claim, you demand everyone else feel the same way, as though you were describing a real property of X. Ask the seminar to generate, individually, their own first-pass explanation of how both halves could be true at once, to be revisited at the end.

Mini-Lecture: The Four Moments of the Judgment of Taste

20 min

Walk through Kant's four moments in order: disinterestedness (a judgment of beauty involves no interest in the real existence or use of the object, unlike judgments of the agreeable or the good); subjective universality (the judgment is grounded in feeling alone, yet claims validity for everyone, unlike a merely private preference); purposiveness without a purpose (the object seems designed or suited to our cognitive faculties, without being referred to any actual concept of its purpose); and necessity (we judge that everyone ought to agree, as a kind of 'exemplary' necessity, though it can't be proven by argument). Have students annotate their excerpt packet with each moment as it's introduced.

Seminar Close Reading: Free Play

20 min

Turn to the excerpt on the 'free play' of imagination and understanding. Facilitate close reading of the passage where Kant proposes that aesthetic pleasure arises from a harmonious, non-conceptual interplay between imagination (which organizes what we perceive) and understanding (which normally seeks to fix perception under a determinate concept) — a state pleasurable precisely because no single concept manages to pin the object down. Push the seminar on whether 'free play' is a genuine psychological explanation or largely a name for the very thing it's meant to explain.

Discussion: The Beautiful vs. the Sublime

15 min

Introduce the sublime as a distinct aesthetic category: the mathematical sublime (an object so vast our imagination cannot grasp it as a whole, prompting a turn to reason's idea of totality) and the dynamical sublime (an object so powerful it threatens us, viewed from a position of safety, prompting awareness of our own rational and moral capacity to resist mere natural force). Apply both to the storm/landscape case and ask whether the sublime is really a variety of aesthetic pleasure or something closer to a moral or rational satisfaction wearing aesthetic clothing.

Closure: Revisiting the Paradox

5 min

Return to the opening paradox and ask each student whether Kant's apparatus (the four moments plus free play) actually resolves it, or merely restates it in more technical language. Collect brief final positions before ending the seminar.

Discussion Questions

- 1 If a judgment of beauty involves no interest in an object's real existence, how do we explain the fact that people often want to own, preserve, or be near beautiful things?

- 2 Kant says the pleasure of beauty comes from a 'free play' between imagination and understanding with no determinate concept — is this a substantive psychological claim, or just a redescription of the puzzle in new vocabulary?
- 3 Is the dynamical sublime really an aesthetic response to nature, or is it closer to a moral or rational feeling (awareness of our own rational dignity) that merely uses a natural scene as its occasion?
- 4 Kant's 'necessity' of taste judgments is not logical or empirical necessity but something he calls 'exemplary' — is this a coherent third category, or an attempt to have the authority of necessity without its actual force?
- 5 Does Kant's framework work equally well for non-natural beauty, such as music or abstract art, or does his apparatus (especially the sublime) lean heavily on examples drawn from nature specifically?

Assessment

Students write a seminar paper (2-3 pages) reconstructing Kant's account of how a subjective, feeling-based judgment of taste can nonetheless claim universal validity, evaluating specifically whether the 'free play' of imagination and understanding does genuine explanatory work or merely relabels the problem, with direct textual citation from the assigned excerpts.

Extension Activity

Have students find a contemporary example of the sublime (a photograph of a hurricane, a piece of vast-scale architecture, a description of deep space) and write a short analysis applying Kant's mathematical/dynamical distinction, evaluating whether his 18th-century framework still captures what feels overwhelming about the example today.

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